



/ RAY_TRACE /
T. NIKOLAI

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FIGMENT LIGHT SPILLS FROM A POINT: A
SUBJECTIVITY.

POINT AND VECTOR

POOLING, IT WRAPS THE HYPOTHETICAL OBJECTS IT
ENCOUNTERS. THE PROJECTION UPON THE THING IS
NOT A PREDESTINATION, BUT A SIMULATION OF THE
POSSIBLE ANCHORED IN THE CIRCUMSTANCES OF THE
PRESENT. AN EXPRESSION OF THE TENDENTIAL. LIKE
THE METAPHOR OF MOONLIGHT ON A LAKE, THE
WATCHER IS LAYERS OF GOSSAMER VIRTUALITY
REMOVED FROM THINGS REAL, BUT NOT ACTUAL.

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- A BRIGHT BLUE BULLET
 - THE MONTEGO BAY
 - HD BOYS

(FOR MIKEY)





A Bright Blue Bullet

A bright blue bullet pulses and fades a mile away across the crystalline playa. Shortly afterward I detect a figgy scent on the wind, Caleb's signature vape. The circle had uncoupled hours ago, but he insisted on some personal time to process the day's events. I knew he needed it so I took up a holding pattern around the obsidian Escalade we rented for the trip. We were baller and we knew it, so why not live a little? YOLO. This retreat had been hard on Caleb, he was feeling emasculated by what Tara said about his ragged breathing during the meditation—a blend of Qigong, tantric technique, and shaman stuff that was blowing up on the radical self actualization circuit. The last of the sun dipped behind Pilot Peak and, with a wet plop, a hunk of salt fell from within the wheel well.

**FOOT
WASH**



The Montego Bay

When [Christopher Columbus](#) for the first time visited [Jamaica] in 1494, he named the bay *Golfo de Buen Tiempo* ("Fair Weather Gulf"). The name "Montego Bay" is believed to have originated as a corruption of the [Spanish](#) word *manteca* ("[lard](#)"), allegedly because during the Spanish period it was the port where lard, [leather](#), and [beef](#) were exported.[\[citation needed\]](#) Jamaica was a [colony](#) of [Spain](#) from 1511 until 1655, when [Oliver Cromwell](#)'s Caribbean expedition, the [Western Design](#), drove the Spanish from the island.

During the epoch of [slavery](#), from the mid-17th century until 1834, and well into the 20th century, the town functioned primarily as a [sugar](#) port. The island's last major slave revolt, the Christmas Rebellion or [Baptist War](#) (1831–1832) took place in the area around Montego Bay; the leader of the revolt, [Samuel Sharpe](#), was hanged there in 1832. In 1975, Sharpe was proclaimed a national hero of Jamaica, and the main square of the town was renamed in his honor...

Today, Montego Bay is known for its large regional hospital (Cornwall Regional Hospital), port facilities, [second homes](#) for numerous upper class Jamaicans from Kingston as well as North Americans and Europeans, fine restaurants, and shopping opportunities. The coastland near Montego Bay is occupied by numerous tourist resorts, most newly built, some occupying the grounds of old [sugar cane plantations](#) with some of the original buildings and mill-works still standing. The most famous of these are the [White Witch's](#) Rose Hall and Tryall, both of which now feature world-class [golf courses](#).

The infrastructure of the city is going through a series of explosive modernizations which once completed, aims to keep Montego Bay as a top destination in the Caribbean and the world.

--From Wikipedia, accessed 12/21/14 at 1:07pm



Every night at two a narrow door in the Montego Bay Resort Spa Hotel and Casino in Wendover, Utah opens. It is located on the first floor, beyond a bank of elevators, beyond disused room 173, and beyond the death rattle of a dried up ice machine. As the aperture widens, a shard of efficient frigid LED glow emanates into the hall's stale amber warmth. At this hour a lock ticks over; Power cords retract and feeding systems of detergents and solvents disengage. What was once a janitor's closet is now the retrofitted den of a hulking PVC tortoise.

With all umbilicals safely drawn away, the thing lurches forward. To accomplish its rounds the Janiturtle must overcome many obstacles. The first, a doorway a fraction of an inch smaller than the beast's bulbous carapace, an oversight in installation. After several minutes of gentle probing clunks followed by a low scrape it successfully locates the deepening groove in the door frame and heaves its bulk into the hall. Bluetooth enabled. Point-cloud library accessed. Carpet sweeping brushes to maximum rpm.

Making an initial circuit of the first floor hallways, protocol dictates attention then be directed to the uppermost floor with routine cleansing proceeding in a downward fashion. All levels are accessed through a perimeter ramp within the hotel's central atrium. Here,

Steroid doped sparrows fitted with elaborate prostheses and stained to appear as exotic birds nest in the rafters beneath a yellowing Plexiglas dome. It is an odd space designed by a local landscaping firm whose experience with exotic plants extended little past a page of search results and the button confirming purchase. The space is profoundly confused, residing aesthetically at some implausible nexus of rain forest, English garden, desert oasis, and miniature golf course. Here, as in all low-end regional casinos the decorators engaged the strategy of the Brute Force Hack, wherein an array of luxury aesthetics are severed from all semblance of cultural context, and recombined into an inscrutable old-world hyper-modernity. Pallid brittle English ivy forms a patchy carpet around a stagnant koi pond beneath impossibly tall, girthy palm trees. Further inspection reveals these trees to be structural support columns covered in preserved palm matter; poorly concealed electrical outlets are an early give away, as are the pendulous obsidian surveillance orbs, obscene omniscient coconuts, nestled high among drooping undersized fronds.



As the hotel fell from favor, fake plants were increasingly brought in to replace species which proved untenable in an environment short on both water and botanical expertise. Even these artifices are showing their age as deep, but not colorfast, greens shift to sun bleached blues. A downy coat of dust clings to their fraying blossoms, more like ash than snow. The dust stands as a skin-flake fossil record of passing vacationers, a tangible accumulation of DNA and inattention. The Janiturtle comes factory equipped with mandibles capable of such delicate tidying, however, its many intricate mouth parts have long since fused under the corrosive weight of decades of bleach-blond hair, gum, and cigarette ash. And so the tortoise passes the ashen flowers by on its ponderous ascent.

Nearing the end of its service-life the nightly climb to the upper floors is a trial for the beast. An acrid spike of scorched plastic trails in the air behind. Distantly accessible in the turtle's metadata is a quasi-memory of simpler times: a spreadsheet detailing bygone periods of lower outputs, higher waste intake, and swift time-to-completion. This file resides encrypted in a basement server, the root user long since terminated. Nevertheless the beast plods its way along the circular mezzanine ramp, past french doors which open onto rooms fully lit, totally disheveled, and only sporadically occupied. In spite of its great struggle the ragged drone of the tortoise is barely

audible below the blaring party anthems echoing over the hotel PA. Periodically the jams fuzz-out to accommodate intervals of garbled promotional announcements. The ongoing Seafood Extravaganza costs \$27.95, beverages excluded.

Approaching the zenith of the machine's ascent it happened again: a pang of Blue Splash. So alike in chemical composition to Citrus Breeze but so persistently alien. Impossibly, it bears the imprint of Technical Concepts, *the Supplier*, but why, queried the persistent turtle, should there be a divergent pattern of cleanser? What about Citrus Breeze could possibly be inadequate? In its epoch of service had the Janiturtle somehow been neglecting a forgotten purpose to which Blue Splash catered? Its core drivers tested upon start-up as uncorrupted, however, being long beyond its period of warranty and support the turtle could not be sure this was the case. What is this uncertain solvent? The chemical, now stored as a molecular map in its database of errant particles, had first alighted upon the turtle one night in the 5th floor skybridge. This place became, unknown to any other, the Janiturtle's nightly point of unmitigated anticipation.



A long standing, and long forgotten, point of bureaucratic contention between the Montego Bay and its neighbor, the Nugget, the skybridge is given only the barest maintenance—existing at the center of a Venn diagram depicting both entities' commitment to neglect. Outside, sparse clusters of neon play Canute against the black desert vacuum. Viewed from within, these scattered opals are smeared soft by the etching action of decades of silicates and less savory particles borne from the military installations that ring the town's outer darkness. Overhead, arched acrylic panels quiver plaintively under screaming microburst winds.

Within the bridge, a smaller breeze pushes a tracery of Blue Splash across the Montego's threshold and over the patient creature's shell. Creeping across carpet the color of Versace, the Janiturtle hastens at the upper limits of its safety protocols toward a logic boundary. Invisible to guests and unaugmented staff, the boundary manifests on the turtle's heads-up display as a translucent red dome enveloping all Montego Bay property and bisecting the skybridge. Beyond this figment wall the machine cannot pass. This fact is reiterated in a series of manic pings originating from the hotel mainframe. In spite of these pleas the turtle presses on along the creaking passage.

The telemetry-stimuli are overwhelming. Here, at the

end of known space, unserviced systems approaching failure state, with Blue Splash concentrations spiking, a kind of giddyness overtook the Janiturtle. It could tell that override signals were being sent from the central computer, but its servos, bewilderingly, continued propelling forward. The turtle could not know that these hardwired, last-ditch relays had long since vitrified in the territory's salty air, and that beneath its housing grew a lurid crystal garden hemorrhaging from every overripe coltan gland—a terminal malignancy gifting a final moment of autonomy.

Amidst a gathering whiteout of warning popups, a glimpse. In a pool of dim fluorescence across the boundary, it stood, nearly imperceptible in the bridge's flickering darkness. The thing beyond was like a black-hole, discernible almost only through what it obscured. In reflecting whorls of blue argon it conveyed the impression of chrome haunches. Narrow mirrored paws swallowed up the arabesques of the floor, and skinned itself in them. With a twitch, this machinic other turned, offering the Janiturtle a brief glimpse of itself mapped onto the thing's diminishing rump. Before it could vanish entirely though, a final window opened foreclosing all vision beyond the imperative to desist.



The wind howls, and within the canopy a small crack spreads wider.

Behind the silent, still Janiturtle, on the carpet to one side of the walkway sits an upended plastic dish. Strawberries, unsettling in the uniformity of both their color and size, litter the floor in a violent arch. Vivid magenta syrup which, until now, sustained and ensconced the dubious fruit congeals, slowly fusing into the stiff pile underfoot.

The sun rises over the eastern mountains purging the shuddering half-light of the bridge, and by noon the passage is sweltering. Vacationers pass through swiftly searching for conditioned air. Ground deeper and baked in, the berries become a part of the place.

"The factory of the future will have only two employees, a man and a dog. The man will be there to feed the dog. The dog will be there to keep the man from touching the equipment."

--Warren Bennis

Traffic, Bicycling, Directions



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HD Boys

Hunter heaved the last of the yellowed CRT monitors onto the pile, and with a quick skip hustled back to the truck. Nephi hooted, and hucked the remains of his Canadian Host onto the heap, shards careening off my Real Tree Wranglers. "Watch it, faggot!" I hollered. Hunter returned with the gas can and doused the whole mess, flicking Nephi playfully with the dregs. The three of us watched in silence as the thing went up. Bubbling, belching plastic housings pooled on the parched quarry floor. Flames of impossible color threw long, gaudy shadows onto the gravel mounds behind us, and the ground lit up like a CD in a microwave as the unwholesome light struck decades of bottle fragments, and a confetti-rainbow of shotgun shells which carpeted the place. A column of black carbon merged seamlessly with the night. We'd stay till dawn when the mess had cooled and the sunrise took over where the colors of the fire left off. With a bent length of rebar, Nephi stirred what didn't burn; the copper cables would get us some beer money on the way back into town.



